prospered and vice versa. Shah has broached the subject intermittently, but now he too had refined his line, speaking of "co-existence" and re-energising local languages along with Hindi, and claiming there was a 'disinformation' campaign to pit Hindi against languages such as Marathi and Tamil. But the remarks were seen as being in service of the old hierarchy—formalised in the idea of a 'national language'. What Stalin found galling was Shah's remark that people should learn Hindi to understand the soul of India's culture and history. "This is an overt sign of dominance," says Stalin, suggesting Hindi Divas be replaced by Indian Languages Day.

The 'One Nation, One Language' policy has few takers in the non-Hindi states, which remain wary of the ethos of cultural dominance lingering from pre-1947 years. In the erstwhile Madras Presidency, ironically, learning Hindi was first made compulsory by C. Rajagopalachari in state public schools—and revoked by the British three years later, in 1940.

Today, Stalin says the Centre is desperate to impose Hindi and Sanskrit on other states via the New Educational Policy—and that if it truly cares about language equality, it should cease favouring Hindi/Sanskrit. Funds allocation is the real test. Outlays for the promotion of Indian languages nearly halved in Union Budget 2022—from Rs 561.47 crore in 2019-20, it dipped to Rs 433 crore for two years, before plummeting to Rs 250 crore this time. Much of this goes as grants to the Rashtriya Sanskrit Sansthan and the Kendriya Hindi Sansthan. Other language institutions—such as those for the promotion of Urdu or Sindhi or studies in classical Tamil—are the ones that suffer because of this skew.



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

'ONE NATION, ONE LANGUAGE' HAS FEW TAKERS OUTSIDE CORE HINDI AREAS. TAMIL'S VETO NOW TOUCHES ALL

Except for Sanskrit, the five Indian languages designated as classical—Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam and Odia—see little government investment. The 'classical' category may valorise a few, but it does show the robustness of the linguistic spectrum outside Hindi/Sanskrit. A language can be designated as classical if there exists a 'high antiquity' of recorded history and an ancient literary corpus, deemed valuable and original, in a classical register distinct from the modern language. Tamil, for one, attests to a rich history that's at least a millennium deeper than that of Hindi.

With historians and linguists highlighting how the Dravidian languages were spread across the Indian Union and beyond its frontiers many centuries before the birth of Hindi itself, these facts have a degree of popular recognition now. Thus, an emerging concern is the growing abhorrence to the 'One Nation, One Language' strategy among youth in non-Hindi states. They perceive it as language imperialism, and it bleeds into economic concerns as migrants from Hindi regions take up semi-skilled and skilled jobs in their states. Their demand for language equality is turning shrill, and is likely to remain till the Centre refines its stand.

In Karnataka, even a BJP government has to bow to this sentiment. In the ongoing session of the assembly, the state will see the Kannada Language Comprehensive Development Bill, fixing the state language as the medium of instruction in schools and colleges and creating job reservation for Kannadigas in the public and private sectors.

"No one can insist on imposing any other language in the state," says chief minister Basavaraj Bommai. That's why Aazhi Senthilnathan, Chennai-based federal and language rights activist, says: "What Stalin has raised is the voice of constitutional equality. It is the voice of leaders from most non-Hindi states." ■